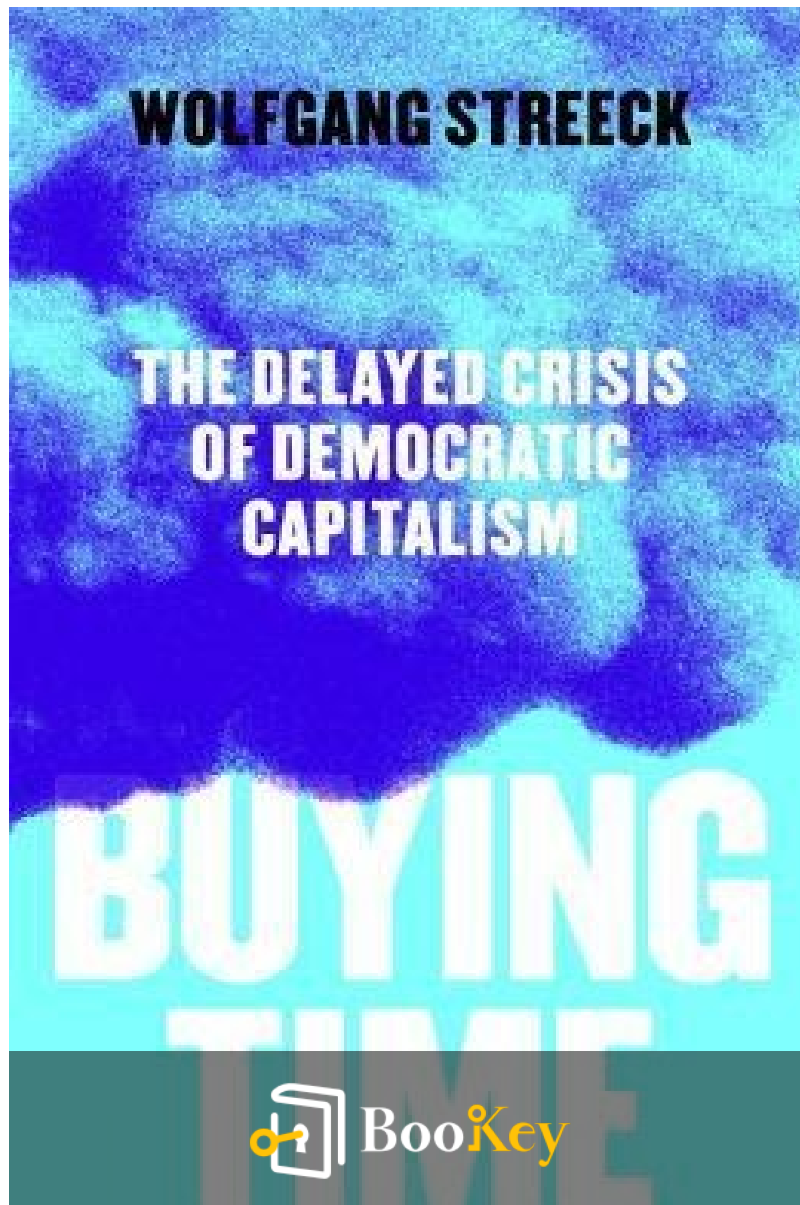


Buying Time by Wolfgang Streeck PDF

Wolfgang Streeck



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The Limits of Capitalism and the Crisis of
Democracy

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About the book

In "Buying Time," Wolfgang Streeck delivers a compelling and incisive analysis of the ongoing economic and political crisis that has come to define contemporary capitalism. With a keen eye for historical detail and an unflinching critique of neoliberal policies, Streeck argues that the current predicament is a result of relentless efforts by states to buy time through financial interventions, thereby delaying the inevitable collapse brought on by deep-seated structural flaws. Delving into the transformation of fiscal states into debt states, the rise of austerity, and the erosion of democratic institutions, Streeck illuminates the intricate connections between economic policies and political power. "Buying Time" is not only a profound diagnosis of capitalism's frailties but also a clarion call for rethinking the socio-economic order, making it an essential read for anyone seeking to understand the forces shaping our world's uncertain future.

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About the author

Wolfgang Streeck, born on October 27, 1946, in Lengerich, Germany, is a distinguished sociologist renowned for his profound insights into the intersections of politics, economics, and societal change. He has held several prestigious academic positions, including the directorship at the Max Planck Institute for the Study of Societies in Cologne. Streeck's work often explores the evolving dynamics of capitalism, labor, and democratic governance, making him a critically influential voice in contemporary social science discourse. His analytical rigor and interdisciplinary approach have earned him wide acclaim, contributing significantly to the ongoing debates about economic crises and institutional transformations.

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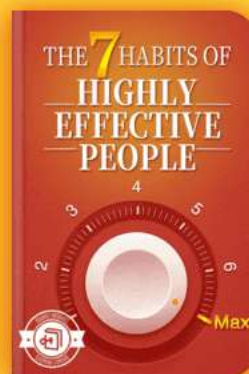
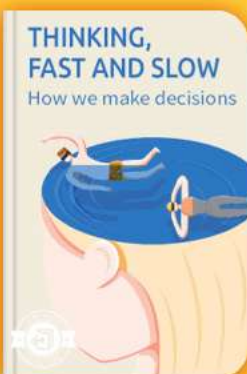


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Chapter 1 : The Origins of the Crisis - Historical Context of Capitalism and Democracy

The post-war economic order marked a significant transformation in the global landscape, characterized by an unprecedented expansion of democratic capitalism.

Following the devastation of World War II, nations sought to rebuild their economies within a framework that balanced the demands of capital with the principles of democratic governance. This period, often referred to as the era of "embedded liberalism," was underpinned by policies that encouraged economic growth while also ensuring social protections and reducing inequalities.

A key feature of this era was the implementation of Keynesian economic principles, which advocated for active government intervention in the economy. Governments around the world adopted policies such as progressive taxation, welfare state provisions, and regulation of markets to stabilize economies and promote equitable growth. This approach facilitated a unique alignment between the imperatives of capitalism and the values of democracy,



fostering an environment where economic prosperity and social welfare could coexist.

However, the inherent tensions between the two systems began to surface even in this seemingly harmonious phase. Capitalism, by its very nature, drives toward continuous growth, accumulation of wealth, and market expansion. Conversely, democracy emphasizes equality, social justice, and the equitable distribution of resources. These fundamental differences set the stage for recurring conflicts and crises, as the pursuit of economic growth increasingly came into conflict with democratic ideals.

Several historical milestones highlight the evolving relationship between capitalism and democracy. The Bretton Woods Agreement in 1944 established mechanisms for international monetary cooperation and exchange rate stability, ensuring a stable environment for post-war economic recovery. The establishment of welfare states in many Western countries during the 1950s and 1960s was a testament to the commitment to social equity and protection of citizens' rights.

However, by the mid-1970s, the post-war economic



consensus began to unravel. Inflation, unemployment, and fiscal crises challenged the sustainability of Keynesian policies. The economic challenges of the 1970s, including the oil shocks and the collapse of the Bretton Woods system, exposed the limitations of the existing economic model and intensified the inherent tensions within democratic capitalism. These crises laid the groundwork for a seismic shift in economic thought and policy, setting the stage for the neoliberal turn that would dominate the subsequent decades.

In summary, the origins of the crisis in democratic capitalism are deeply rooted in the historical context of the post-war economic order. The delicate balance achieved through embedded liberalism, while successful for a time, could not indefinitely reconcile the conflicting demands of capitalism's growth imperative and democracy's focus on equality. This foundational tension has resurfaced in various forms over the decades, leading to the complex and multifaceted crisis we face today.



Chapter 2 : The Shift from Embedded Liberalism to Neoliberalism

The latter part of the 20th century witnessed a significant transition in economic policy paradigms, moving from embedded liberalism to neoliberalism. This shift marks a pivotal juncture in the economic landscape, characterized by a departure from Keynesian policies—rooted in state intervention and social welfare—to a model that prioritizes market-driven approaches. Embedded liberalism, which arose in the aftermath of World War II, was predicated on the notion that governments should play an active role in smoothing economic cycles through fiscal and monetary policies, promoting full employment, and ensuring social welfare. This approach facilitated a period of sustained economic growth and social stability in many Western nations.

However, the economic crises of the 1970s, marked by stagflation—simultaneous inflation and stagnation—posed a formidable challenge to Keynesian principles. Policymakers and economists began to question the efficacy of state intervention in the economy. This climate of economic



uncertainty paved the way for the ascendance of neoliberalism, a framework advocating for reduced government intervention, deregulation, privatization of public enterprises, and an overarching faith in the efficiency of free markets.

As neoliberalism took root, marked changes in economic and social policies became evident. Deregulation policies removed many of the constraints that had been placed on businesses and financial institutions, seeking to unleash market forces believed to drive innovation and economic growth. Privatization initiatives transferred ownership of previously public assets and services to private entities, with the aim of enhancing efficiency and competitiveness. Globalization, another cornerstone of neoliberal doctrine, facilitated the flow of goods, services, and capital across borders, fostering interconnectedness and economic interdependence among nations.

The transition from embedded liberalism to neoliberalism had profound impacts on economies and policy landscapes. Countries previously supported by robust welfare states began scaling back social programs and public services in favor of market solutions. Labor markets were liberalized,



often leading to increased job insecurity and inequality as protections for workers were diminished. The influence of multinational corporations and financial institutions grew, often at the expense of national sovereignty and local economies.

Various case studies highlight the decline of state intervention in markets under neoliberalism. In the United Kingdom, Prime Minister Margaret Thatcher championed sweeping reforms that drastically reduced the role of the state, dismantling much of the industrial base and privatizing numerous public services. The United States, under President Ronald Reagan, witnessed similar policies aimed at tax reductions, deregulation, and curbing the influence of labor unions. These changes heralded an era where market supremacy overshadowed social considerations, fundamentally altering the relationship between the state and the economy.

The impact of these neoliberal policies is a subject of ongoing debate. Proponents argue that deregulation, privatization, and globalization spurred economic growth, innovation, and efficiency. Critics, however, point to the exacerbation of income inequality, erosion of public welfare



systems, and increased economic volatility. The diminished capacity of states to regulate economic activities and provide public goods has, according to many, left societies vulnerable to the excesses of market forces.

In summary, the shift from embedded liberalism to neoliberalism represents a critical transformation in modern economic history. It underscores the complex dynamics between state intervention and market freedom and sets the stage for understanding subsequent developments in global capitalism and the challenges faced by democratic institutions in reconciling economic efficiency with social equity.



Chapter 3 : Financialization - The Turn to Debt and Financial Markets

Part 3: Financialization - The Turn to Debt and Financial Markets

In "Buying Time," Wolfgang Streeck delves into the concept of financialization and its profound impact on modern economies, governance, and the unfolding crisis of democratic capitalism. Financialization refers to the increasing dominance of financial motives, financial institutions, and financial elites in the operation of economies and the distribution of resources. This shift has restructured the way economic value is generated and distributed, transforming both the private and public sectors in the process.

A core aspect of financialization is the turn to debt as a central mechanism for managing economic crises and funding public expenditures. Governments, facing growing fiscal pressures and diminishing tax revenues, increasingly relied on borrowing to finance their operations. This reliance on debt was not merely a reaction to economic downturns but



became a systematic feature of fiscal policy. For households, businesses, and states alike, access to credit and financial markets became a critical factor. The proliferation of credit instruments and the expansion of consumer debt enabled continued consumption even amidst stagnant wages, masking underlying economic vulnerabilities.

Streeck argues that this dependence on debt has facilitated short-term policy solutions at the expense of long-term stability. By postponing necessary but politically difficult reforms, democratic states bought time, hence the title of the book, but at the cost of accruing massive debts. This has left many economies vulnerable to financial shocks and crises, as evidenced by the global financial crash of 2007-2008. The need to service and manage debt has increasingly influenced policy decisions, often prioritizing the demands of creditors and financial markets over the welfare of citizens.

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Chapter 4 : The European Crisis - A Case Study of Austerity and Political Strain

Part 4: The European Crisis - A Case Study of Austerity and Political Strain

The European debt crisis, which surfaced in the wake of the global financial meltdown of 2007-2008, serves as a critical case study for understanding the far-reaching implications of austerity measures and their strain on political and social stability. This period brought to the fore the fragility of national economies within the Eurozone and tested the structural and ideological integrity of the European Union (EU). At the heart of the crisis was the problematic relationship between sovereign debt and supranational governance, highlighting deep-seated weaknesses in the EU's economic architecture.

The crisis began with Greece in 2009, rapidly spreading to other Eurozone countries like Ireland, Portugal, Spain, and Italy. Sky-high public debt levels and significant deficits exposed these economies to the unforgiving assessments of



global financial markets. As investor confidence waned, borrowing costs soared, leaving these nations teetering on the brink of insolvency. The EU, alongside the International Monetary Fund (IMF), stepped in with bailout packages contingent on strict austerity measures, a decision that reflected the prevailing neoliberal orthodoxy of the time.

These austerity measures included severe cuts to public spending, tax increases, and labor market reforms aimed at reducing budget deficits and restoring market confidence. However, the social and economic ramifications of these policies were profound and, in many cases, devastating. Public services and social welfare programs were drastically reduced, leading to widespread hardship, especially among the most vulnerable populations. Healthcare, education, and pension systems faced significant cutbacks, undermining the social safety net that had been a cornerstone of post-war European democracies.

The political strain caused by these measures was equally significant. In many countries, austerity sparked mass protests and social unrest. Public trust in national governments and EU institutions plummeted as citizens perceived these bodies as being more responsive to the



demands of financial markets and international creditors than to the democratic will of their populations. This erosion of trust was particularly noticeable in countries like Greece, where the economic downturn and subsequent bailout conditions led to a collapse of traditional political parties and the rise of anti-establishment movements.

Moreover, the crisis exposed the democratic deficit within the EU's decision-making process. Critical economic policies were being engineered and enforced by technocrats in Brussels and the IMF, often with minimal input from the electorates of the affected countries. This created a perception that national sovereignty was being eroded in favor of a technocratic and undemocratic oversight. The terms of the bailout agreements, determined largely by Germany and other economically robust member states, seemed to many to be punitive and lacked empathy for the socio-economic realities on the ground.

The democratic implications of the EU's responses were substantial. The imposition of austerity measures often bypassed national parliaments, undermining the role of elected representatives and stripping democratic processes of their legitimacy. This contributed to the emergence of



Euroscepticism and a surge in support for populist parties across the continent, as citizens sought to reclaim national autonomy and resist external impositions. The crisis thus ignited a broader debate over the future of European integration and the balance between economic governance and democratic accountability.

In conclusion, the European debt crisis and the ensuing austerity measures revealed the inherent tensions within the EU's political and economic framework. The crisis underscored the challenges of maintaining economic stability and growth while preserving democratic principles and social cohesion. The fallout from this period continues to shape the political landscape of Europe, influencing debates on economic policy, governance, and the very nature of the European project itself.



Chapter 5 : The Rise of Technocracy - Governance in the Age of Austerity

The rise of technocracy in recent times has marked a significant shift in governance, especially in the context of ongoing economic austerity measures. Historically, democratic systems have relied on elected representatives to make policy decisions, ensuring that governance reflects the will of the people. However, as global economic pressures have intensified, there has been a noticeable departure from this model towards one where experts, rather than elected officials, wield substantial power.

Technocratic governance places emphasis on the role of specialists and experts in policy-making, often at the expense of broader democratic participation. This shift manifests in various ways, such as the appointment of non-elected technocrats in key governmental positions or the creation of independent regulatory agencies with significant decision-making authority. These changes are often justified on the grounds that complex economic and financial issues require specialized knowledge that the general populace, and by extension their elected representatives, presumably lack.



The implications of this shift for democratic accountability are profound. As decisions increasingly fall into the hands of experts, the typical avenues for citizen participation and oversight can become obscured or bypassed altogether. Policies that affect broad swaths of the population might be formulated and implemented with minimal public debate or input, thereby diminishing the role of democratic deliberation. The entrenchment of technocratic governance raises critical questions about whom the government serves and how responsive it is to the needs and desires of its constituents.

Exemplary cases illustrating this entrenchment include the handling of the European debt crisis. In several instances, struggling economies have seen technocrats assume control at crucial junctures. For example, Italy and Greece experienced the replacement of their elected leaders with technocratic governments, citing the need for expertise in steering their countries out of fiscal turmoil. While these interventions were often praised for their effectiveness in implementing stringent economic reforms, they also sparked widespread debate about the erosion of democratic principles.



Moreover, the influence of supranational institutions, such as the European Central Bank and the International Monetary Fund, has reinforced this technocratic trend. These bodies, primarily staffed by experts with significant autonomy from direct democratic control, have played pivotal roles in determining the economic policies of member states, further distancing economic governance from the reach of ordinary citizens.

Technocratic governance, by prioritizing expertise over electoral input, presents a conundrum for contemporary democracies. While the effectiveness and efficiency of expert-led policies can provide short-term solutions to complex problems, these approaches can undermine the essential democratic values of accountability and representation. The challenge, therefore, lies in finding a balance that maintains the integrity of democratic governance while adequately addressing the technical complexities of modern economic issues.



Chapter 6 : Repercussions of the Crisis - Populism, Inequality, and the Future of Democracy

The prolonged economic crises triggered a series of severe social and political repercussions, fundamentally reshaping the landscape of modern democracy. One of the most prominent outcomes has been the surge in populist movements across the globe. These movements often capitalize on widespread discontent with established political orders, presenting themselves as the voice of the marginalized and disillusioned citizens. The rise of populism can be viewed as a direct response to the failures of neoliberal policies which, while promoting economic growth and market efficiency, have exacerbated social inequalities and eroded public trust in traditional political institutions.

Populist leaders frequently exploit the growing divide between elites and ordinary citizens, channeling frustration and anger towards perceived out-of-touch governments and technocratic elites. This dynamic fuels a cycle of polarization, where populism thrives on amplifying socio-economic grievances and promising radical, often



simplistic solutions. The consequence is a political environment marked by heightened antagonism and the erosion of democratic norms, including respect for minority rights and the rule of law.

Simultaneously, widening inequality has emerged as another formidable threat to the sustainability of democratic institutions. The shift towards neoliberalism, with its emphasis on deregulation, privatization, and austerity, has led to a significant concentration of wealth and income among a small elite. This increasing disparity not only undermines social cohesion but also skews political influence, as those with substantial economic resources wield greater power over policy decisions. As the gap between the rich and the poor widens, the principle of political equality—a cornerstone of democracy—becomes increasingly compromised.

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I've learned. Highly recommend!

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Chapter 7 : Pathways Forward - Alternatives to Neoliberal Capitalism and Strategies for Reform

In the concluding section of "Buying Time: The Delayed Crisis of Democratic Capitalism," Wolfgang Streeck outlines potential pathways forward that aim to resolve the deep-seated tensions between capitalism and democracy. Streeck acknowledges the complexity of these issues and the difficulty in charting a definitive course of action but puts forward several key ideas for consideration and debate.

One significant suggestion Streeck offers is the need for a radical reform of international financial systems. The current global financial architecture, he argues, has facilitated the rise of neoliberal policies and the dominance of financial markets over democratic decision-making. To counter this, Streeck proposes a reorientation towards more regulated and transparent financial practices. Such reforms might include stricter controls on speculative investments, enhanced international cooperation to curb tax evasion and avoidance, and the implementation of policies that prioritize long-term economic stability over short-term financial gains.



Streeck also emphasizes the importance of promoting sustainable economic policies that balance growth with social and environmental considerations. The relentless pursuit of GDP growth has often come at the expense of social welfare and ecological health. Therefore, he advocates for a shift towards a more sustainable model of capitalism that incorporates environmental protection, equitable distribution of resources, and investment in social infrastructure. In this context, policies such as a universal basic income, progressive taxation, and robust social safety nets could play crucial roles in mitigating inequality and ensuring that economic prosperity benefits a broader swath of the population.

Furthermore, Streeck highlights the essential role of political engagement and activism in driving these reforms. Democratic capitalism can only be revitalized through active citizen participation in political processes and a robust civil society that holds leaders accountable. Grassroots movements, labor unions, and other forms of collective action are pivotal in pressuring governments to adopt policies that reflect the will and needs of the populace rather than the interests of a wealthy elite. Streeck posits that fostering a



culture of engaged citizenship and reinvigorating democratic institutions are critical steps towards building a more equitable and democratic society.

Finally, Streeck invites readers to consider the broader ideological shifts that may be necessary to imagine and implement alternatives to the current neoliberal framework. He calls for intellectual and cultural openness to new economic paradigms that prioritize human well-being over profit maximization. By challenging the entrenched assumptions of neoliberalism and exploring innovative ideas such as cooperative ownership, social enterprises, and participatory economics, society can begin to envision and work towards a more just and sustainable future.

In summary, Wolfgang Streeck's "Buying Time" offers a comprehensive and critical examination of the delayed crisis of democratic capitalism, while also providing thought-provoking suggestions for pathways forward. His call for financial reform, sustainable economic policies, political engagement, and ideological innovation provides a framework for addressing the systemic issues at the heart of the current crisis and moving towards a more inclusive and democratic economic order.

